

RELAPSE TRIGGERS

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Increase awareness of potential relapse triggers.
2. Identify coping techniques for each relapse trigger.
3. Accept powerlessness over mood-altering substances and the need for a structured recovery program that includes the help of others.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Chemical Dependence—Relapse

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

Although the client may be able to identify the people, places, and things that are the strongest potential triggers for relapse, he/she may need significant guidance in listing coping techniques for each of these triggers. Let the client struggle on his/her own to identify these coping skills before providing support and additional guidance. More than one coping technique may be recommended for a particular trigger situation.

RELAPSE TRIGGERS

Alcoholics Anonymous (AA) refers to people, places, and things that can initiate a relapse into substance abuse as relapse triggers. It is very important that you try to identify those people or situations that may increase your vulnerability to the temptation to return to substance abuse. Identifying the triggers for substance abuse is a first step that must be followed by a plan for coping with each of these triggers if you are to minimize the power of their influence over you in the future.

1. List at least 10 people, places, or things that your experience has taught you will tempt you to return to the use of mood-altering substances. Consider such things as friends or associates, family members, drug or alcohol-using locations, places to purchase drugs or alcohol, strong emotions that have been associated with drug or alcohol use, recreational activities associated with use, financial situations that provide opportunities for use, and so on.

A. _____

B. _____

C. _____

D. _____

E. _____

F. _____

G. _____

H. _____

I. _____

- J. _____

- K. _____

- L. _____

2. Consider each of the triggers that you have listed and write down a positive way that you can cope with this situation, person, or emotion in order to not return to substance abuse. You may need to consult with your counselor about coping techniques, but attempt to come up with some of these on your own. Consider such things as AA meetings, sponsor contact, higher-power meditation, positive support groups, positive relationships, one-to-one counseling, avoidance of specific friends or places, keep-ing money out of your hands, increasing recreation, and so on.

- A. _____

- B. _____

- C. _____

- D. _____

- E. _____

- F. _____

- G. _____

- H. _____

- I. _____

- J. _____

- K. _____

- L. _____

3. What are the three most important triggers that you need to be alert for in order to avoid their powerful influence?

A. _____

B. _____

C. _____

4. What are the three most important coping skills that you believe will help you maintain your sobriety?

A. _____

B. _____

C. _____